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Design Thinking

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Guidelines for the User Interview:

- Interviewing international students at Dartmouth from developing countries (List)
- Introduction → short questions first → story-based questions.
- Don't take more than 20 minutes per interviewee. Be aware of their time!
- "Why do you think X or Y?"
- Say thank you for their time.

Interview Questions:

- Could you introduce yourself?
- Talk about your childhood memory of growing up in your country. What are the challenges girls face in accessing education in your country?
- How did technology affect your education? What did you wish to see in your education in line with technology?
- What was your transformation like at Dartmouth (claiming there's a lot of technology here)?

Interview Notes, 5/4 and 5/5:

Amen from Yemen:

- He is a sophomore majoring in Economics. He shares that Yemen is a war-torn country, and is afraid to come back to his country.
- His memories of growing up include a small school with a lot of pupils in it. "We depend on chalk, old tables and a board." Sometimes girls are forced to marry early. Because of fear of violence, parents are afraid to send their girls to school.
- "Technology wasn't really prevalent in schooling in my country." It was hard to find a stable internet to apply to Dartmouth.
- "I wish there could be more access to Wifi and computers, so more children could apply to schools abroad. Also, teaching a foreign language is challenging due to the shortage of teachers in the field."
- "At Dartmouth, there's so much innovation and technology here. I was and still am amazed by the resources in classrooms and technology throughout the campus."

from Myanmar:

- Freshman student majoring in Engineering. He shares that Myanmar has been suffering from a civil war since 2021, and he shares he's also afraid to leave the U.S.
- "My childhood memories are both positive and negative. Until the civil war, it was mainly good, as I didn't have to worry about being shot or sent to the military by my country. I'm thinking that for girls, it's even more challenging. Most parents don't send their girls to school, because it's too dangerous. There have been many cases of rape, or physical attack on girls. Many families flee from one place to another, which results in the disruption of girls' education."
- "Technology is growing in cities in Myanmar. However, in rural areas it's still the same old ways of teaching and educating children, purely based on textbooks and old curriculum." He wishes there were ways to build more schools faster, given the conflict disrupting schools. That way, girls wouldn't have to walk long distances.
- "Here it's different. It's like a bubble here. Dartmouth protects so much from the external world, but I always worry about my family back home. There's running water *with* technology, everything is automatized."

Vani from India:

- She's from Delhi. She grew up in a city, which could be a very different experience compared to someone growing up in a village in India. She's interested in STEM and government.
- There were a lot of traditional roles of women that were insisted upon when I was growing up. Girls barely spoke up about gender violence, and they struggled to communicate their needs to their parents. Early marriage is still in practice in many parts of India. One of the challenges girls face is as basic as going to school. If it requires transportation like a subway, it becomes almost impossible for girls, because public transportation is almost always male-dominated.
- India is growing and integrating technology with education in cities. I had good access to the internet; however, schools still lacked computers or modern ways of teaching. I wish rural schools had more resources like projectors to involve visual teaching.
- My transformation was pretty smooth, and I found some new technology and wished they existed in many schools of India.

Arshad from Afghanistan:

- Majoring in engineering with architecture (modified major). Grew up in Kabul (the "advanced city" of Afghanistan).
- Lovely childhood. He has five sisters. "It was definitely tough for girls, and for my sisters. Especially because of traditional views, but my family always supported them. Now two of them are doctors. My little sisters are at school in Pakistan after we fled." His sisters went to a co-ed school in primary, but then we had to separate from that time on because of Islamic traditions.
- No technology is really exhausted in public schools. They didn't have electricity. I use an Ipad here, but I had to depend on the notebooks, piles of them. Some people don't even

know about computers. “Now it feels like we’re going backward in the life of Afghanistan now.” Electricity shortages everyday in Kabul.

- Here all education depends on computers and the internet, everything should be submitted online.

Joel from Sri Lanka:

- He’s majoring in Engineering Physics. He went to a private school in Sri Lanka, where he had an international A levels. This is different from public schools, because they have local A levels, which are administered by the Sri Lankan government. His school was co-ed, whereas in public schools it’s separated by gender. Traditionally, it’s been like that.
- In comparison to the U.S., I thought it would be very developed here, but the difference wasn’t as large as he expected to be. “I would say that the average town in Sri Lanka is a lot less developed than the average American city.” “Personally, in my school, there wasn’t a gender disparity that was visible. Girls and boys had relatively equal opportunities; however, in Sri Lankan culture, outside of the bubble of my school, it’s very obvious that girls have less opportunities than boys be it in education or sports.”
- Technology only became important to him after Covid, all his classes shifted online. A good number of students from public schools had to switch to his school, just so they would have access to education during the pandemic. The vast majority of kids in public schools had to stay in the same grade for years, because of the pandemic halting the education.